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Culture (OWC): [Shona \(FS05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1967-1972

Coverage Date: 1967-1972

Place Coverage: Northeastern Zimbabwe

Section Title(S): THE MUZUKURU

In some places such as Chilimanzi, the nephew is given a beast for his services in caring for the deceased's affairs. (This gift is known as *mbwazukuru*). The nephew holds a position of respect and status in his mother's brother's village. He has certain privileges but at the same time knows his limitations. On no occasion could he prove to be a danger to his uncle. Because of his position he may learn some of his uncle's secrets and if he is dishonest he may reveal them to others. He may even become too friendly with his uncle's wife or be tempted to have relations with the wives of his uncle's sons.

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Administration

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Status, Role, And
Prestige

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Avuncular And Nepotic
Relatives

There is a saying among the Shona which implies that when the uncle (mother's brother) dies the nephew has the right to marry his widow. This may well happen if the dead man has no brothers to inherit his wife. Thus a nephew may become familiar with his aunt because he holds this position in the family and enjoys this peculiar freedom in his uncle's village. He can joke with his aunt who can retort in the same vein saying that he (the *muzukuru*) is a *muroora*, implying that he is like a young wife as he is descended from her husband's sister. However, the joking relationship is much more in evidence between the nephew and his cousins' wives. Familiarity between the nephew and his uncle and his wife is not encouraged. He must show respect for the status of his uncle and his family. Therefore it is considered most immoral for any nephew to stoop to having sex relations with his maternal aunt or with the wives of her sons. His aunt's daughters he calls *amainini*.

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Secondary Marriages

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Cousins

He not only shows respect to his father's sister's eldest son, but also to her other sons, though the eldest is the important one in his eyes. As a sign of

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respect the uncle may kill a goat when his nephew visits his village.

Status, Role, And
Prestige

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The nephew may be consulted about minor quarrels in 42 his uncle's village but if they are slightly more serious the paternal aunt is preferred, especially in emotional upsets. For instance, a quarrel between a recently married couple is more a matter for the paternal aunt than for the nephew.

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Ingroup Antagonisms

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Relatives

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